ing) exponent Desa Mangaiyarkarasi. The priests are also eligible for a monthly honorarium of Rs 500.

Besides the renovation of shrines that are more than a thousand years old, 15 temples are also in for an "iconic transformation". These are places that have a special significance in the state's religious pantheon. "The ambience of the temple and its grounds is being transformed. Rituals and processes for worship will be streamlined," says Mohan. Some 560 temples will see their precincts developed based on master plans. The HR&CE is also fast-tracking maintenance in temples where the once-in-12-years *kumbhabhishekam* ritual is coming up. Already, 650 temples have been consecrated. Giving a facelift to the *rajagopurams* (temple towers) and chariots is another priority. Of the 1,097 wooden chariots belonging to 854 temples, 34, which are in bad condition, are being repaired in the first phase. New chariots are also being built for 16 temples. A research centre is being set up at the office of the commissioner, HR&CE, to conserve the palm leaf manuscripts in the repositories of many temples and digitise the content.

TACTICAL PLOY

There is no denying that the regime's pro-Hindu efforts come at a time when the Madras High Court is hearing a slew of past petitions on temple mismanagement and an aggressive BJP is trying to get a foot in the door in the state. Diehard detractors maintain the department is bad for the temples and want them "freed" of government control. They say that India, being a secular country, should not have state 'control' of religious institutions. Places of worship of other religions, like mosques and churches, are not under government control, so why temples? "State control of temples is wrong," says T.R. Ramesh, president of the Indic Collective and Temple Worshippers Society. "Articles 25, 26 and 29 of the Constitution are violated by appointing executive officers in the temples of Tamil Nadu. It is causing tremendous damage to the interests of deities and devotees. Moreover, temples of different *sampradayas* (traditions) cannot be brought under a single board." Others allege financial mismanagement by the HR&CE department. State BJP president K. Annamalai alleges it "exploits the temple *hundi* (till)" despite taking 16 per cent of the revenue—12 per cent towards administrative expenses and 4 per cent for audit. "There is a huge gap between the amount spent on auditing and what is charged to the temples," he says.

Ex-finance and current IT and digital services minister P. Thiaga Rajan (PTR), though, dismisses the critics. "Most of these warriors for 'privatising temples' have done little for their welfare...in fact, many of the 'privatise' claimants historically made a living out of the temple assets and donations," he says.

The legislation to manage temples is close to a hundred years old. PTR's grand-uncle M.T. Subramania Mudaliar had, in fact, played a role in the legislation of the Hindu Religious Endowments Act, 1927. The Justice Party pioneered the act that led to the constitution of the Madras Hindu Religious Endowments Board and the appointment of executive officers to temples. There was opposition from entrenched groups, but Panagatti Ramarayaningar, the then premier of the Madras Presidency, convinced British viceroy Lord Irwin and got his approval.

Post-Independence, the Madras Hindu Religious Charitable Endowments Act, 1951, led to the creation of a department of HR&CE. Many interested groups challenged it as the law abolished the system of hereditary employees and empowered the state to regulate the affairs of Hindu temples and mutts. After prolonged litigation, the TN HR&CE Act, 1959, finally came into force.

Over the decades, however, oversight weakened. Today, vacancies to trustee posts for 560 temples with an annual income of over Rs 10 lakh are being filled. The Madras HC has asked the state to appoint trustees in all 38 districts by May-end. These trustees manage the temples, which the HR&CE oversees while contributing to the administrative costs. The temples contribute to the administration fund depending on their capacity and income.



"TEMPLES ARE SYMBOLS OF OUR ART AND CULTURE. IT IS OUR DUTY TO PROTECT THEM. THOSE WHO SAY WE ARE ANTI-HINDU DO NOT UNDERSTAND DRAVIDIAN TENETS... WE ARE ONLY OPPOSED TO FANATICS, NOT RELIGION"

M.K. STALIN
Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu

A TOURIST ATTRACTION

The state has a stake in its temples also because 600,000-800,000 people visit them daily, the numbers doubling on weekends and holidays and rising manifold on festival days. Tamil Nadu has retained the top spot in religious tourism for over a decade, recording 134 million tourist footfalls. To sustain this pilgrim flow, the state is pulling out all the stops. The state tourism development corporation, which has packages for pilgrims, now also offers bookings for temple-owned guesthouses through its Alayam service. Health centres are being developed near temples. At the hilltop temples in Palani, Anuvavi in Coimbatore and Thirukazhukundram in Chengalpattu, ropeway cars are being installed. Chennai and Mahabalipuram have the first-of-their-kind climate-resilient green temples. These "self-sufficient temples" boast of basic utilities such as drinking water, as well as solid waste treatment plants, solar lighting and microplastics management facilities. "All these measures are people-centric," says Kundrakudi Ponnambala Adigalar, head of the Thiruvannamalai Mutt. "Their impact on the faith will be felt over time." Mohan, too, believes credibility has gone up, "which is why devotees too are donating generously." It also helps that norms for 'donor-led works' have been eased. In restoring shrines of the Hindu faith, Stalin, it seems, is inviting people to have faith in his government. ■